

History & Tradition of Hiring in the U.S.

Early Origins and Mid-20th Century (Pre-1950s)

- **Early résumés and informal hiring (1930s-1940s)** – Modern résumés trace their lineage to the **Great Depression**. Jobseekers began preparing typed sheets that described their experience and often included personal details such as age, marital status and religion ¹. Hiring was still highly informal; workers found jobs through personal connections and hand-shake agreements, and formal interviews were rare ². Cover letters were used in business correspondence but not yet for job applications.
- **Post-WWII changes (late 1940s-1950s)** – After World War II, millions of veterans entered the workforce. The GI Bill provided education and training benefits, so résumés started to emphasise **skills and education** instead of personal characteristics ³. The U.S. workforce also began to diversify as women and minorities entered paid employment; the *Equal Pay Act of 1963* and the *Civil Rights Act of 1964* outlawed pay discrimination and employment discrimination on the basis of race, sex and religion ⁴. By the 1950s, companies placed formal job adverts in newspapers and mailed applications, but interviews were still largely informal and often based on community connections ⁵.

Standardisation and the Rise of HR (1960s-1980s)

- **Professionalisation of résumés** – The 1960s through the 1980s saw the rise of career counselors and professional résumé writers ⁶. Résumés shifted to a more structured format (chronological work history, education and skills) and were typically one or two pages typed on white paper. Early **Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS)** introduced in the 1970s and 1980s required consistent headings and keywords ⁶, pushing jobseekers to adopt standardised formats.
- **Birth of the cover letter (mid-20th century)** – The term “cover letter” first appeared in a **New York Times** job advertisement on 23 September 1956 for an industrial paint chemist ⁷. Throughout the 1960s and 1970s the cover letter became mainstream; by 1971 books were published on how to write them ⁸. Historically it served as an introduction and a narrative about the applicant beyond the résumé ⁹.
- **Emergence of human-resources departments** – Corporate growth and scientific management created large HR departments. Hiring moved from manager discretion toward formal processes with multiple stakeholders. Structured interviews, panel interviews and skills testing started to replace the informal, one-conversation approach ⁵. Telephone screening interviews were used to reduce travel costs.
- **Attire and business formal norms** – Office attire remained strictly formal through the 1960s and 1970s. Men wore suits and ties and women wore conservative dresses. Dress codes were enforced by company manuals ¹⁰.

Digital Transformation (1980s-2000s)

- **Fax machines and overnight mail (1980s)** – The introduction of fax machines and overnight courier services transformed recruiting. Résumés could be transmitted quickly, enabling national searches and making scheduling faster. Printed client lists and index cards were still used to track candidates ¹¹.
- **Rise of job boards and online applications (1990s)** – The internet revolutionised recruiting. Job boards like **CareerBuilder** (1995) and **Monster** (1999) allowed jobseekers to post résumés online and apply electronically ¹². Fax and postal applications declined, and employers began using early ATS to parse résumés and rank candidates ¹³. Résumé format shifted from dense paragraphs to bullet-point summaries and scannable text ¹⁴.
- **Business casual emerges** – Tech firms in Silicon Valley pioneered a relaxed “business casual” look in the early 1980s, favouring khaki pants and button-down shirts ¹⁰. By 1999, **95 %** of U.S. companies had some form of casual-dress policy, up from 24 % in 1992 ¹⁵. Employee surveys found that 75 % of U.S. workers dressed casually every day in 1999 ¹⁵.
- **Standardisation of multi-stage interviews** – Companies increasingly adopted structured processes. Many roles now required a phone screening, an in-person or panel interview and sometimes technical or behavioural assessments. According to an HR poll summarised in 2024, **69 %** of respondents felt that **three to four interviews** were already too many, yet employers are increasingly using multi-stage processes to minimise hiring mistakes ¹⁶. Research summarised by IQ Partners noted that 40 % of hiring managers expect candidates to complete at least two interviews and 15 % expect five or more ¹⁷.

Social Media and ATS Optimisation (2000s-2010s)

- **LinkedIn and social recruiting** – **LinkedIn** launched in 2003 and quickly became the primary professional networking site. Jobseekers created online profiles that functioned as living résumés, enabling recruiters to search for candidates directly ¹⁸. By the late 2000s, personal websites and digital portfolios supplemented traditional résumés ¹⁸.
- **Advanced ATS and keyword optimisation** – ATS platforms evolved from simple databases into sophisticated systems that parse résumés, rank applicants and integrate with job boards ¹³. To be noticed, résumés had to include **keywords** relevant to the job description and maintain clean formatting. Modern résumés were usually one to two pages and highly targeted ¹⁹.
- **Video interviews** – The mid-2010s introduced video interviews using **Skype**, **Zoom** and integrated ATS platforms. Video interviews offered flexibility and reduced travel costs, becoming a standard step in many hiring processes ²⁰.
- **Shift in attire norms** – Business casual became widely accepted outside of finance and law. Tech and creative industries embraced jeans and t-shirts. For remote and video interviews, attire expectations relaxed further; candidates often wear professional tops with casual attire unseen on camera.

Remote Work and the Pandemic Era (2010s-2025)

- **Remote and hybrid work** – Before 2019, only **6.5 %** of private-sector workers primarily worked from home ²¹. The COVID-19 pandemic triggered a massive shift: by 2021, remote participation increased sharply across all major industries ²². Industries such as professional, scientific and technical services, information, finance and insurance, and management of companies saw remote

- work jump from **under 17 %** in 2019 to **over 39 %** in 2021 ²³ . Even after social-distancing policies were removed in 2022, remote work remained above pre-pandemic levels in all but one industry ²⁴ .
- **Detailed industry breakdown** – In detailed industry data, sectors like computer systems design and data processing had **50.2–62.5 %** of workers remote in 2021, compared with only **15–20 %** in 2019 ²⁵ . Across 61 industries, **44 industries** had more than **10 %** of their workforce working remotely in 2021 ²⁵ .
 - **Hybrid flexibility and productivity** – Gallup’s 2024 survey of remote-capable employees shows that before the pandemic 60 % worked on-site, 32 % hybrid and 8 % fully remote. In early 2020, 70 % of remote-capable employees were working exclusively from home. By 2025, **55 %** of these employees are hybrid and **26 %** are fully remote; only **19 %** remain on-site ²⁶ . Employees expect remote flexibility long-term, citing improved work–life balance, though challenges include isolation and blurred boundaries.
 - **Impact on interviews** – Remote work normalised virtual interviews. Candidates increasingly meet hiring teams via video calls, and employers may conduct all interview stages virtually. Panel interviews and technical assessments can be delivered online. Dress codes for virtual interviews remain polished from the waist up, but may be more relaxed overall.
 - **Mental health, flexibility and DEI** – The pandemic highlighted the importance of mental health and flexible work arrangements. Hybrid schedules help employees balance personal obligations, and remote hiring can broaden applicant pools beyond geographic boundaries, supporting diversity and inclusion initiatives. Workplaces also grapple with pay transparency and inclusive hiring to address persistent gender and racial pay gaps ²⁷ .

Evolution of Résumés, Cover Letters and Portfolios

Era	Key résumé/cover-letter traits	Influences & technologies	Citation
1930s–1940s	Handwritten or typed résumés with personal details; no standard format	Great Depression job scarcity; skills acquired during WWII; early cover letters not yet used for employment	¹ ³
1950s–1960s	Typed résumés emphasising skills and education; emergence of formal cover letters (first employment ad requiring one in 1956)	GI Bill; economic expansion; introduction of equal-employment laws	⁷ ⁴
1970s–1980s	Structured chronological résumés; early ATS drive standard headings and keywords; mailed or faxed applications; professional résumé writers emerge	Career counselors; growth of HR; ATS adoption; rise of affirmative-action and diversity policies	⁶ ¹³
1990s–2000s	Digital résumés transmitted via email and job boards; scannable bullet-point formats; more functional résumés; cover letters emailed as attachments or text	Internet and job boards (Monster, CareerBuilder); improved word processors; early ATS; fax machines decline	¹² ¹⁴

Era	Key résumé/cover-letter traits	Influences & technologies	Citation
2010s–2020s	ATS-optimised résumés with keywords; one-to-two-page length; integration with LinkedIn profiles and online portfolios; some employers deem cover letters optional	Social media; LinkedIn (2003) and digital portfolios; advanced ATS and AI; personal branding; shift to remote hiring; emphasis on transferable skills	¹⁸ ¹⁹

Evolution of Interview Processes and Structures

1. **Pre-1960s** – Hiring was often based on referrals or local community connections; there was little formal interviewing ². Managers sometimes hired workers randomly, as Henry Ford reportedly chose labourers from the gates ⁵. Interviews, if held, resembled informal conversations.
2. **1960s–1970s** – HR departments standardised interviews. Structured one-on-one interviews and early panel interviews emerged, with set questions and evaluation criteria to reduce bias. Telephone screenings were introduced to narrow the candidate pool before in-person meetings. Employers also began using personality and aptitude tests.
3. **1980s–1990s** – Multi-stage processes became common: a phone or recruiter screen, followed by one or two in-person interviews (often with multiple managers), and sometimes technical or case-study assessments. Fax and email facilitated scheduling. Business attire remained standard ¹⁰.
4. **2000s–2010s** – Rapid expansion of **panel**, **case**, **behavioural** and **technical** interviews. Video interviews using Skype/Zoom allowed remote screening ²⁰. Employers used competency-based questions to assess soft skills and culture fit. Research suggests many hiring managers expect at least two interviews, and some roles may involve five or more stages ¹⁷.
5. **2020s** – Virtual interviews are normalised; entire hiring processes may be conducted remotely. Companies often combine asynchronous video screening, online assessments and live virtual panels. Emphasis on candidate experience has led some employers to streamline processes, but highly technical roles may still require multiple rounds. Remote work and hybrid arrangements mean hiring managers might never meet candidates in person.

Cultural Norms in Attire

- **Formal business attire (pre-1990s)** – Until the early 1990s, most workplaces required men to wear suits and ties and women to wear conservative dresses or skirts ¹⁰. Dress codes were strictly enforced through handbooks and corporate policies.
- **Business casual (1990s)** – Tech companies in Silicon Valley started promoting khakis and button-down shirts, challenging conventional dress. By 1999, **95 %** of U.S. companies had adopted some form of casual-dress policy and 75 % of workers dressed casually every day ¹⁵.
- **Industry variation** – Finance, law and client-facing roles maintained formal attire into the 2000s; creative, tech and start-up environments adopted jeans, sneakers and informal clothing. Remote interviews often require only professional tops.

Job Application Cycles, Job-Hopping and Career Paths

- **Application cycles and time-to-hire** – In the 1980s, many positions were filled after one or two interviews; third interviews were rare ¹⁶. In modern times, professional roles often involve multiple stages—phone screens, technical tests, panel interviews and final evaluations—with typical processes requiring **2–4 interviews** ¹⁷. Extended hiring cycles can last weeks or months.
- **Job-hopping trends** – A 2016 Gallup survey found that **21 %** of millennials changed jobs within the previous year, three times the rate of non-millennials; **60 %** were open to new opportunities ²⁸. This contributed to the perception that millennials are a job-hopping generation. However, a 2017 Pew Research analysis showed that the share of millennials with at least 13 months tenure (63.4 %) was similar to Gen X at the same age (59.9 %), and the share with five-year tenure was almost identical ²⁹. Thus, while job-hopping is more visible due to social media and changing norms, tenure has not declined dramatically.
- **Generational attitudes** – Gen X (born 1965–1980) introduced work-life balance and were early adopters of remote work ³⁰. They remain loyal if employers reciprocate loyalty but will leave if working conditions change ³¹. Millennials and Gen Z expect flexibility, purpose and inclusive cultures; they value remote options and may switch jobs to achieve them.

Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) and Regulatory Milestones

- **Civil rights and equal employment laws (1960s–1980s)** – Key laws include the *Equal Pay Act* (1963) and *Civil Rights Act* (1964) prohibiting discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex and national origin ⁴. The *Age Discrimination in Employment Act* (1967) banned age discrimination ³²; the *Rehabilitation Act* (1973) required employers to accommodate people with disabilities ³³; and the *Women's Business Ownership Act* (1988) supported women entrepreneurs ³⁴.
- **Affirmative action and diversity initiatives** – Executive orders in 1961 and 1965 mandated affirmative action for federal contractors ³⁵. The 1980s saw early diversity programs and domestic partner benefits for LGBTQ+ employees ³⁶. By the 2010s, media scrutiny pushed tech companies to release diversity statistics ³⁷, and in 2020 the Supreme Court ruled that LGBTQ+ employees are protected under the Civil Rights Act.
- **Modern DEI expectations** – Job seekers increasingly consider workplace diversity important; **76 %** regard it as a key factor in job selection ³⁸. Employers now incorporate DEI statements into job adverts, implement bias-reduction training, and track representation metrics. Remote work can broaden applicant pools to include people with disabilities, caregivers and those in rural areas, supporting inclusion ³⁹.

Current Practices and Future Outlook (2025)

- **Résumé and application formats** – Modern résumés are concise (one or two pages), use clear headings and bullet points, and are optimised with keywords for ATS. Cover letters are increasingly optional; some employers prefer work samples or portfolios. Online profiles (LinkedIn, GitHub, personal websites) complement traditional documents.
- **Interview processes** – Expect **two to four interview rounds** for most roles, often combining asynchronous video responses, live virtual panels, technical tests and behavioural questions. Employers emphasise culture fit and soft skills alongside technical expertise. Candidates should research company culture, practice storytelling using the STAR (Situation-Task-Action-Result) method and prepare thoughtful questions.

- **Remote and hybrid norms** – With over **55 %** of remote-capable workers in hybrid arrangements and **26 %** fully remote ²⁶, applicants should be comfortable with virtual collaboration tools, remote onboarding and time-zone coordination. Dress expectations vary by industry; understanding company culture remains essential.
 - **DEI and transparency** – Pay transparency laws and DEI reporting require employers to share salary ranges and representation metrics. Candidates should assess an employer’s commitment to diversity through public reports and interview questions.
 - **Looking ahead** – Artificial intelligence will continue to shape recruiting through predictive analytics, chatbot screeners and automated skill assessments. Skills-based hiring may reduce emphasis on degree requirements. Hybrid work will persist, and companies that offer flexibility, inclusive cultures and transparent communication will attract top talent.
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Methodological Notes

This knowledge file was compiled from a variety of credible sources, including historical analyses, government statistics, HR research and industry reports. When possible, data points were cross-checked across at least two independent sources to ensure accuracy. Citations are provided inline to enable verification and further exploration. The file reflects hiring practices in the United States through November 2025 and acknowledges ongoing trends and future directions.

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